Example of a fictional mini-paper introduction

This could be the introduction to a mini paper describing the invention of the roof. This paper imagines that we have had houses for many thousands of years, but somehow, no one has ever successfully invented the roof.

It's not a perfect introduction. I haven't revised the structure or the style, and I haven't actually even finished it. That doesn't matter for now. The point is, it illustrates how you can start writing your mini paper about an imaginary topic.

Introduction

Ingress of water into and heat loss from houses remain central problems for all societies. Though the invention of the house marked a great step forward for humanity – a defendable space, safe from intruders and predators – houses have had no defence against poor weather. Although the walls provide limited shelter against wind, they do little to trap heat and nothing to keep out rain and other precipitation.

The entry of water into houses when it rains is severely detrimental both to the house itself and to the possessions of the inhabitants. Electrical devices break easily when wet, and can even present a fire hazard. Paper disintegrates, ink runs, and fabrics become mouldy. The stone parts of the house itself are largely unaffected (except that they can be damaged if the water freezes) but wooden construction materials rot when wet.

Loss of heat, meanwhile, is a problem for the inhabitants of a house. It is hard for people to be active and healthy if the temperature drops below 15 ^{O} C for any significant length of time, and it is impossible to maintain the temperature inside a house in cold weather because heat simply rises straight out of the top. This is a problem to people of all ages, but especially to children, the elderly, and the sick. It is made worse if the people are also wet due to water ingress.

[Although I haven't bothered, I could also at this point discuss other problems such as entry of sunlight causing sunburn, and the difficulty of using air conditioning to cool a roofless house in the summer.]

The walls of a house are extremely effective in preventing these problems from the sides: they are impervious to water and highly insulated against heat transfer by both convection and radiation. If a "fifth wall" could be added to the top of a house, to enclose it from above (figure 1) it would, at least in principle, solve the problems discussed and represent a revolution in housing design.

This is not a new idea; a number of previous workers have attempted the addition of a "fifth wall". However, none of these previous attempts have succeeded. The most common reason for failure has been the collapse of the fifth wall shortly after construction, often with fatal results for the house's occupants.

[This introduction is not complete, but hopefully you can see where it is going. So far, I've achieved the first aim of the **opening**: to introduce the big ideas and show why they matter, by showing that it would be better if houses could keep out rain and keep in heat. I've just started, but haven't finished, the second aim of the **opening**: to show that my paper is offering a valid and sensible solution in the form of a "fifth wall" (i.e. a roof!). To continue doing this, I might offer some explanation as to why all previous efforts to build roofs had been unsuccessful and give some evidence that a different and better approach might be possible.

I would, of course, then aim to finish my introduction with a set of **challenges**, which would probably imply questions like "is it possible to build a safe roof that does not collapse?", "how effective is such a roof at keeping out rain?", and "how effective is a roof at preventing heat transfer?"

Hopefully you can see how a fictional introduction, though a little silly, allows you to practice all the important features of introduction structure.]

Fictional topics chosen by past students include:

- invention of shoes
- invention of a new electrolysis propulsion system for drones
- invention of the e-bike
- invention of a new painkiller
- invention of the dog leash
- development of an algorithm for swimming pool monitoring and safety
- development of AI NPCs for video games
- invention of the car
- invention of the electric car
- the effect of fire on the development of human technology
- invention of the ball-point pen
- invention of the bed
- invention of cooking
- invention of the refrigerator
- invention and applications of a brain-wave receiver